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Culture (OWC): [Zulu \(FX20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1951

Coverage Date: 1800-1951

Place Coverage

Makhanya tribe, Umbumbulu township, Umlazi District, KwaZulu-Natal Province, South Africa

Section Title(S)

1. PREMARITAL LOVE RELATIONSHIPS • CHAPTER XIII Pagan Marriage • Ukuthembisa (promising)

Allowing for all these aspects, marriage among the Makhanya is also a contract between two exogamous groups, represented by senior agnates. Special attention will be given in the following exposition to the nature of the reciprocal efforts to initiate and conclude this contract by the two groups involved. These when subsequently summarized will be found to constitute a symmetrical system of group obligations, directed towards the satisfaction of certain social values.

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So complex a system of institutions does not achieve its full momentum at once by the immediate interaction of two social groups, but is set in motion by the personal relationships of the two persons primarily involved.

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[Basis Of Marriage](#)

1. PREMARITAL LOVE RELATIONSHIPS

Pagan marriage usually arises out of the matrix of interpersonal love-relations in which young people engage from the age of about 14 onwards. These are at first not directed towards marriage at all, but are rather concerned with establishing one's personhood (*ubuntu*) in society. Lacking *rites de passage* in the form of an initiation school and ceremony, the Zulu seem to place special emphasis on success in making one's mark on adolescent society, and so passing into adult life as a person worth mentioning.

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There is accordingly an aggressive as well as a compliant element in relations between the sexes during adolescence. For either sex to fail to attract a lover is serious; and yet courtship must not be made too easy for the boys, who take the initiative. Pagan girls, as they come into the love-game, accordingly learn from their elder sisters the methods of quick repartee and ridiculing young men by words. Correspondingly the latter, by listening to their brothers and older men, learn how to *kilela* the girls—to entrap them in speech. They are also taught the use of medicines to make themselves more attractive sexually and to thwart their rivals.

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Ukuthembisa (promising)

Sooner or later a girl will indicate her favour towards a young man by ceasing her gibes and becoming coy. In the olden days a girl on the first occasion of love could not *thembisa* directly at all, for this involved a promise to *soma* (often called *hlobonga*, have intercrural intercourse),¹ of which she had no detailed knowledge. She would 176 accordingly communicate her love to her elder sisters, who would instruct her in the implications. After some time the eldest girl would meet the boy and tell him that her sister inclined to his love. This constituted *thembisa* and was a sign that the matter could be made public.

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¹ It is interesting that the same verb, *soma*, is also used to mean **joke** or sport, apparently indicating that aggressive **joking** and external intercourse have at least some values in common.

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